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COSIMA Cookbook: a computational learning module for analysing ocean and sea-ice model output

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Software

- Review
- Repository
- Archive

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Summary

The COSIMA Cookbook is an open computational learning module for analysing ocean and sea-ice model output in Jupyter notebooks. It has been developed by the Consortium for Ocean-Sea Ice Modelling in Australia (COSIMA; https://cosima.org.au) as a community resource for researchers, students, and practitioners working with large gridded datasets, especially output from the ACCESS ocean-sea ice model configuration (Kiss et al., 2020). The repository combines introductory tutorials with worked analysis examples, all exposed through a browsable Sphinx documentation site (Figure 1) and backed by a citable archived release (Constantinou et al., 2026).

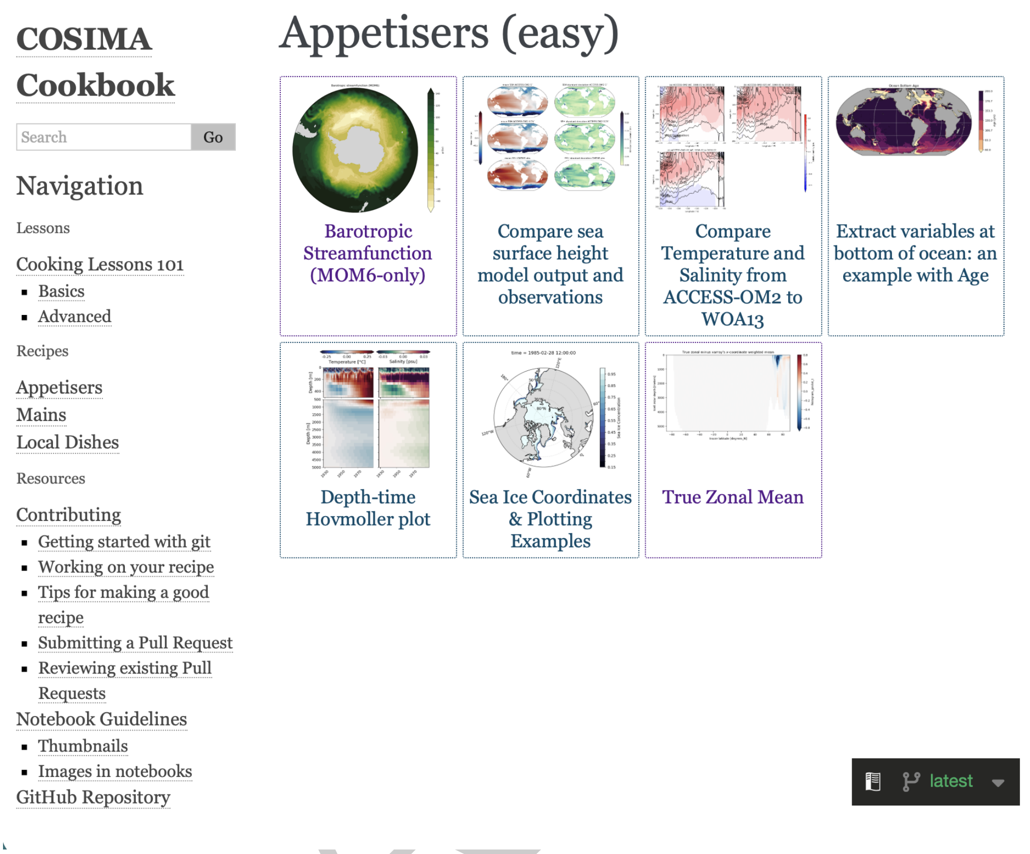

Figure 1: The COSIMA Cookbook documentation website, showing the browsable Sphinx-based landing page used to navigate tutorials and recipes. The live site is available at https://cosima-recipes.readthedocs.io.

Following the "Cookbook" concept, the website sections are deliberately named using a gastronomy theme. "Cooking Lessons 101" refers to tutorials that teach generic, transferable techniques for handling ocean–sea ice model output; next come the "Appetisers" that are easier recipes that provide a good entry point after the tutorials; "Mains" are more elaborate and advanced analysis examples, and "Local Dishes" collect recipes for regional model configurations (Barnes et al., 2024). Together these sections present the documentation as a browsable collection of lessons and recipes gathered into a single cookbook.

Pedagogy and instructional structure are central to the project. The idea is that these recipes provide the starting point for more elaborate analyses. "Cooking Lessons 101" introduces generic skills such as loading model output, working with labelled arrays, plotting, and interacting with shared data catalogues. These tutorials lead into domain-focused "recipes": self-contained notebooks showing how to perform concrete diagnostics and analyses on ocean and sea-ice datasets. The current repository contains dozens of notebooks grouped into introductory, advanced, and region-specific collections, giving learners an incremental path from first contact with the data ecosystem to adaptation of full workflows for their own science questions.

Within this structure, the tutorials include examples of loading model output through intake-based catalogues (Intake developers, 2026) and incorporating Cartopy (Elson et al., 2024) for map-based visualisation. The recipe collection also includes a Lagrangian particle-tracking workflow built with Parcels (Lange & Sebille, 2017), as well as analyses that use xgcm (Abernathey et al., 2022) to handle variables defined on staggered finite-volume grids and xESMF (Zhuang et al., 2025) for regridding model output.

The Cookbook grew from a practical need inside the COSIMA community: the tools used to analyse modern ocean model output are powerful, but the gap between package-level documentation and a reproducible end-to-end workflow remains large. Users need to understand not only Python and Jupyter (Kluyver et al., 2016), but also how to navigate high-dimensional model output, shared high-performance computing environments, and domain-specific analysis conventions. The Cookbook addresses that gap by packaging reusable workflows in the same medium in which users actually work.

Statement of Need

Ocean and climate model analysis has a steep entry cost. New users must learn how to find datasets, load them efficiently, interpret metadata, operate on multi-dimensional arrays, and produce scientifically meaningful diagnostics. General-purpose libraries such as xarray (Hoyer & Hamman, 2017) provide the foundations for these tasks, but they do not by themselves show a learner how to translate a research question into a robust analysis workflow for a specific model and computing environment.

The COSIMA Cookbook fills that need with a domain-specific, openly maintained collection of computational lessons and examples. Its contribution is not a new analysis package; rather, it is a reusable learning resource that makes existing scientific software, data conventions, and model output more approachable. This aligns well with JOSE's emphasis on open educational resources that enable computational learning through authentic practice.

Several design decisions make the Cookbook particularly useful for adoption by other groups. First, each notebook is intended to be self-contained and well-documented, so learners can read, run, and modify a complete workflow without reconstructing missing context from scattered notes. Second, the repository distinguishes tutorials from recipes. Tutorials teach transferable skills, while recipes demonstrate how those skills combine in realistic analysis tasks. Third, the project includes contributor guidance and notebook review conventions that encourage new analyses to be written in a reusable and pedagogically clear style. A caveat is that some recipes use high-resolution model output with datasets of order terabytes, so the underlying data are not always practical to distribute or mirror in full. However, beyond the initial data-loading step, which usually occurs early in each recipe, the analysis workflows are generally applicable to most operational ocean–sea ice model outputs that can be loaded with xarray (Hoyer & Hamman, 2017).

Thus, the structure is valuable beyond the immediate COSIMA context. Many research communities maintain model output on shared infrastructure and face the same challenge: turning expert tacit knowledge into examples that newcomers can adapt. The Cookbook offers a model for how a scientific collaboration can capture that knowledge in version-controlled notebooks, publish it as a living resource, and continuously improve it through community contribution.

Educational Design and Experience of Use

The learning experience is organised as a progression. The documentation points new users first to introductory lessons, including material on loading, slicing, and visualising model output. Learners then move to more advanced tutorials and finally to recipe notebooks that address concrete scientific questions. The categories of "appetisers", "mains", and "local dishes" provide a lightweight pedagogical cue about expected complexity and scope, with "local dishes" specifically covering recipes for regional model configurations (Barnes et al., 2024).

The intended mode of use is also explicit. The repository is designed around Jupyter-based analysis on the Australian National Computational Infrastructure, with guidance on running notebooks through ARE/JupyterLab sessions and on accessing shared data holdings. This makes the Cookbook more than a static collection of examples: it is operational documentation for a real analysis environment. At the same time, the notebooks demonstrate broadly transferable patterns for working with labelled geophysical data, so individual lessons can be reused or adapted outside that environment.

The project also supports community authorship. Contributors are encouraged to submit new notebooks through pull requests, document their methods clearly, and generalise workflows so that they remain useful to others. In that sense, the Cookbook functions both as a learning module for end users and as a framework for teaching reproducible scientific communication through notebook design and peer review.

Author order

The first two authors contributed equally; authors from the third position onward are listed alphabetically by surname.

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